Beijing. The two countries would establish diplomatic relations on January 1, 1979, and embassies on March 1. The mutual defense treaty with Taiwan would be terminated, and Washington would follow a one China policy while maintaining unofficial relations with Taiwan.

Subsequently, Deng traveled to the US in January. The Carter administration wanted to convince the Chinese leader that the US would remain "a credible counterweight" to the Soviet Union in Asia, and to move from consultation to cooperation and coordination where interests converged with China. On South Asia, the administration sought to encourage improved Sino-Indian relations and continued Chinese support of Pakistan, but also wanted Beijing to discourage the Pakistani nuclear program. Brzezinski also suggested that Carter try to get "the Chinese to look more favorably upon an active Indian role in the subcontinent as [a] force against Soviet expansion."[192] This went a bit further than the recommendations of the US chiefs of mission in South Asia but they, too, had noted the many overlapping Sino-US interests vis-à-vis India and Pakistan. The ambassadors had indeed suggested not just informing Beijing of Washington's South Asia strategy but also seeking its support.[193]

Deng's visit took place as things were heating up in Afghanistan, as well as in Southeast Asia because of the Vietnamese invasion of Cambodia and overthrow of its China-backed regime. The Chinese leader expressed concern about what he described as a Soviet "barbell"—referring to Moscow's strengthened positions in Southeast Asia and in the eastern Indian Ocean region, connected by the sea. Brzezinski stressed that this made the importance of India "greater than ever" and Sino-Indian rapprochement crucial. Deng concurred, while adding that Desai's seeming willingness to recognize the Vietnamese-backed regime in Cambodia was a sign of persisting Soviet influence. He was not as keen on American proposals to press Islamabad on its nuclear program and asked why the US "could not turn a blind eye to the nuclear reprocessing issue."[194] Subsequently, Carter told him that the US was trying to "renew [its] strong ties with Pakistan," but would have to terminate aid if Islamabad developed a nuclear capability.[195]

American officials were aware that India would watch the Deng trip closely. After a trip to Delhi, Thornton had reported Indian concern that "the US will now turn away from [India] towards China," providing that